



height, blue eyes, and blonde hair to their Viking ancestors. Today, the Scandinavian countries tend to be industrialized with a good standard of living. Most of the population is concentrated in the south,

though plenty live within the Arctic circle. Officially Scandinavian countries have Christianity as their national religion, but religious practice is weak and beliefs are often blended with pre-Christian elements.

WELFARE STATES

Taxes in Scandinavia are set high, but in return people benefit from excellent welfare services. Denmark provides the best state child support in Europe. A parent may take an entire year off work to care for a baby while still, in most cases, being paid in full.



GRADUATION DAY

At their graduation ceremony students wear a distinctive white cap with a red or blue band. After the ceremony, students, still wearing their hats, drive around the streets in decorated open-topped cars and vans with music blaring, tooting their horns.



CITY OF BIKES

Bicycle travel is common in Denmark, where the government encourages people to cycle rather than drive. Copenhagen is even known as the City of Bikes. On average, every Dane cycles two miles (3 km) per day, and even the Prime Minister is often seen out and about on his bike.

CONNECTING COUNTRIES

The idea for a bridge uniting Sweden and Denmark is not a new one. Suggestions date back to the 19th century. The plans finally came to fruition in 2000 with the opening of the Øresund Bridge linking Malmö in Sweden with Copenhagen in Denmark. At 10 miles (16 km), it is the longest single bridge in the world to carry both road and railroad traffic.

